

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | **TUESDAY, MAY 19, 2026** | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

\$1.7B fund to pay Trump’s allies

Cash envisioned for mistreatment claims against Biden DOJ

By **Fatima Hussein, Eric Tucker and Alanna Durkin Richer**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration announced Monday the creation of a \$1.7 billion fund to compensate allies of the Republican president who believe they were mistreated by the Biden administration Justice Department, an arrangement that Democrats and government watchdogs derided as “corrupt” and unconstitutional.

The “Anti-Weaponization Fund” of \$1.776 billion is part of a settlement that resolves President Donald Trump’s lawsuit against the Internal Revenue Service over the leak of his tax returns. It will allow for people who believe they were targeted for prosecution for political purposes to apply for payouts, creating what acting Attorney General Todd Blanche called “a lawful process for victims of lawfare and weaponization to be heard and seek redress.”

“The machinery of government should never be weaponized against any American, and it is this Department’s intention to make right the wrongs that were previously done while ensuring this never happens again,” Blanche said in a statement that made no mention of how investigations and prosecutions of Trump’s political opponents under his watch have exposed the Justice Department to the same claims of politicized law enforcement that he said he opposed.

Nearly 100 Democrats in the House of Representatives signed on to a legal brief urging a judge to block what they described as an unprecedented resolution that they said would unjustly enrich people close to the president with taxpayer dollars and invite meritless claims of political persecution.

“This is one of the single most corrupt acts in American history,” Donald Sherman, the president of Citizens for Responsibility and Ethics in Washington, said in a statement.

The fund would represent not only a highly unorthodox resolution but also a further demonstration of the administration’s eagerness to reward allies who before Trump returned to power were investigated and in some cases charged and convicted. Most notably, the president on his first day back in office pardoned or commuted the sentences of supporters who rioted at the U.S. Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021. His Justice Department since then has approved payouts to supporters

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Golfers tee off at Lost Marsh Golf Course in Hammond, Indiana, on Wednesday, with the backdrop of BP Whiting Refinery and Lake Michigan.
E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Bears’ Hammond site would be on slag heap

Proposal puts stadium near hazardous waste sites and refinery

By **Robert McCoppin**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As the mayor of Arlington Heights, Jim Tinaglia leads the charge to build a Chicago Bears stadium there. In his private job as an architect, Tinaglia said he would be very leery of building on the rival proposed site in Hammond, Indiana.

“I would throw up the red caution flags immediately,” he told the Tribune. “I’ve worked on enough sites with gas stations or dry cleaners or some sort of hazardous material to know it contaminates the ground. I would be very concerned about selecting a site like that.”

Tinaglia is not the first to voice concerns about the site near Wolf Lake in Hammond. In the past, area residents fought to get the site cleaned up. The result was a golf course built on top of a mountain of slag — a rocky waste product from steel production — that was capped with bio-solids that are treated human waste.

The location also sits near several hazardous waste sites, across the street

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“Thirty or 40 years ago, northwest Indiana was a very different place. Much of that was from the State Line Generating coal plant that was shut down (in 2012). We’ve been tightening emissions over the years and really cleaned up our air a lot.”

— **THOMAS MCDERMOTT JR.**,
Hammond mayor

Above: Hammond Mayor Thomas McDermott Jr. waits to speak before the House Ways and Means Committee at the Indiana State House during testimony on Feb. 19 for Senate Bill 27, which creates the financial structure for a Bears stadium.
ANDY LAVALLEY/FOR THE POST-TRIBUNE

Pritzker optimistic for deal but knocks Johnson for ‘no plan’

By **Olivia Olander**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Gov. JB Pritzker said Monday he expects the Illinois General Assembly to pass legislation incentivizing a Chicago Bears stadium and other major development projects before the end of the spring legislative session, while also repeatedly ding Mayor Brandon Johnson for having “no plan” to keep the team in Chicago.

“That’s problematic. I’d love them to be in the city, but we’re three years in now, and he still has no plan,” Pritzker said of the first-term mayor, who earlier this month during a visit to Springfield made a last-ditch effort to claim the Bears needed to keep playing their home games in Chicago.

The state House passed a so-called megaprojects bill last month that would allow the Bears to make special payments to local governments in lieu of higher property taxes, an effort to keep the team in Illinois rather than losing it to Indiana.

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State’s attorney launches transit crime prosecution task force

Law enforcement agencies at federal and local levels to team up

By **Talia Soglin**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Cook County state’s attorney’s office Monday announced a new task force made up of local and federal law enforcement agencies that it says will strengthen efforts to prosecute crime on public transit.

The task force will include a plethora of law enforcement agencies — including the Cook County

sheriff’s office, the Chicago Police Department, the U.S. attorney’s office and the FBI — as well as the Chicago Transit Authority, Metra and Pace.

At monthly meetings to begin next week, task force members will “review processes that will assist in effective and efficient charging and prosecution of transit crime,” according to guidelines released by the state’s attorney’s office.

“When we get all oars in the same water rowing in the same direction, we can make significant progress,” Cook County State’s Attorney Eileen O’Neill Burke said

at a news conference Monday at the Roosevelt Red Line Station. Acting CTA President Nora Leerhsen pledged the mass transit agency was “fully committed to ensuring open communication and the seamless exchange of any data needed to advance the task force mission.”

The task force comes on the heels of an internal task force launched by the state’s attorney’s office earlier this year. And it’s separate from another law enforcement task force mandated by the state’s landmark transit funding and reform legisla-

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Acting CTA President Nora Leerhsen, from left, speaks with Cook County Sheriff’s Office Chief of Police Arthur Jackson and Cook County State’s Attorney Eileen O’Neill Burke ahead of a news conference announcing the creation of the Regional Transit Task Force at Roosevelt CTA station in Chicago’s South Loop on Monday. **JOSH BOLAND/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘Broadview Six’ trial draws near

A federal judge said she will review unredacted grand jury transcripts in the case against Operation Midway Blitz protesters. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Trump’s approval rating drops

Most voters think President Donald Trump made the wrong decision to go to war with Iran, a New York Times/Siena poll found. **Nation & World**

Cubs star ‘regrets word choice’

Pete Crow-Armstrong says his response to fan who heckled him in the outfield at Guaranteed Rate Field was ‘heat of the moment’ thing. **Chicago Sports**

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